matured in December, whereas what she wanted to do was to start in June so that the lump sum would be available the following year in time for school reopening. All that was needed was a simple fix that would have made a big difference to her and to the bank. But the bank did not oblige her!

When in Ernakulam in November 2012 for a conference, I went for a morning walk. I noticed that hundreds of labourers were gathered at the main street corner. Just from their appearance, it was clear that they were not locals. On inquiry, I found that they had come from the North-east for manual labour in Kerala. I struck up a conversation with them and learnt about the work they do, how much they earned, where they ate and lived in Ernakulam, and why indeed they had travelled 3000 kilometres across the country for eking out a livelihood.

I was particularly curious to know how they were sending money back home to their families. I gathered that out of hundreds of them, only a dozen or so could meet the KYC requirement to open a bank account in Ernakulam, but they got around that with some resourcefulness. Each of the dozen or so account holders would service dozens of others, who did not have bank accounts. Each of them would deposit the amount he wanted to send to his family back home into a designated bank account, and the account holder would text his wife about the respective shares. At the North-east end, his wife would withdraw the money with her ATM card and disburse amounts to each family in accordance with the remittances made in Kerala.

I was impressed by their enterprise. I was also embarrassed by my ignorance. Here was big phenomenon—massive migration of labour across a 3000-kilometre diagonal of the country—and I, as the governor of the Reserve Bank, was not even aware of it.

I happened to go back to Ernakulam after stepping down from the Reserve Bank. The regional director of the Reserve Bank there told me that they have since started disseminating material on financial literacy in Bengali and Assamese and that it would soon extend to other languages.